Week 9: The Art of Biblical Poetry

How to Read the Bible — 19-Week Study

Biblical poetry works differently than narrative — tonight we'll look at how, and why it rewards slowing down.

1. Do you gravitate toward poetry, or does it usually go over your head? Is there a song lyric, quote, or line of poetry that has stuck with you over the years? What makes it memorable?

2. **Read Psalm 29.** How many times does the phrase "the voice of the LORD" turn up? Strip away the poetry and the psalm is describing an ordinary thunderstorm — rolling in off the sea, breaking over the northern mountains, moving south into the desert. What is the poem claiming about that storm by calling the thunder God's "voice"?

3. Look again at Psalm 29. The opening (vv. 1-2) says "Ascribe to the LORD" three times; a line like verse 5 says nearly the same thing twice ("The voice of the LORD breaks the cedars; the LORD breaks the cedars of Lebanon"). Biblical poetry is built on this doubling, and the second line almost never just repeats the first. Pick a couplet and work out what the second line adds, sharpens, or intensifies. What does that doubling do to the pace of your reading?

4. **Read Judges 4:17-22, then Judges 5:24-27.** The death of Sisera is told twice — first as narrative, then, one chapter later, as poetry in the Song of Deborah. What does the poem let you feel, or linger on, that the plain account doesn't? Why might the Bible keep both versions?

5. **Read Psalm 51:1-12.** David reaches for one image after another — a stain that needs washing, a record that needs blotting out, guilt "ever before" him, a heart that has to be created new. Why do you think one image wasn't enough for him? Which of these pictures for sin or forgiveness rings most true to your own experience?

6. **Read Psalm 8.** What two things does this short poem set side by side — the vast night sky, and what else? How does holding both in one small poem land

differently than a flat statement that "humans matter to God"?

7. Poetry is terse by design — it says more by using fewer, more carefully chosen words rather than explaining everything outright. Why might God have chosen to reveal so much of who he is, and so much of what he asks of us, through compressed poetry instead of straightforward prose?

8. If a third of the Bible is written to be slowed down and savored rather than read quickly for information, how does that change the way you typically approach your Bible reading, if at all?

9. Pick one line from Psalm 29, the Song of Deborah, Psalm 51, or Psalm 8 that stood out to you tonight. What would it look like to actually sit with that single line this week instead of moving on to the next chapter?